

LET ME TRY · FREE PRINTABLE

Instead of “Good Job”: 30 Phrases That Build Confidence

What the research says about praise · Ages 2–4

Praise isn't bad. But praise that labels the child (“good girl”, “so smart”) can make children more cautious and more dependent on approval. Praise that describes what they did helps them keep trying.

What the research found

- ○ Children praised for intelligence chose easier tasks and gave up faster after failure than children praised for effort (Mueller & Dweck, 1998).
- ○ Toddlers whose parents used more process praise at ages 1–3 had a stronger 'I can learn' mindset five years later (Gunderson et al., 2013).

Describe what you see

- ○ “You used red, yellow and blue!”
- ○ “You put every block back in the basket.”
- ○ “You poured it slowly so it didn't spill.”
- ○ “You buttoned that one all by yourself.”
- ○ “You drew a really long line here.”

Notice the effort

- ○ “You kept trying until it fit.”
- ○ “That was tricky, and you didn't give up.”
- ○ “You tried a new way.”
- ○ “You worked on that for a long time.”
- ○ “You practised, and now it's easier.”

Ask, so the joy stays theirs

- ○ “How did you do it?”
- ○ “Which part was hardest?”
- ○ “What will you try next?”
- ○ “You look proud. Are you?”
- ○ “Tell me about your picture.”

Thank them for helping

- ○ “Thank you for setting the table. Now we can eat together.”
- ○ “You helped Dadi carry the bag. That was kind.”
- ○ “You shared your crayons with Riya. She looks happy.”

Remember

You don't need to remove every “good job”. Aim for fewer, and add one describing sentence after it: “Good job! You put all the spoons away.”

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Mueller, C. M., & Dweck, C. S. (1998). Praise for intelligence can undermine children's motivation and performance. Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 75(1), 33–52.
Gunderson, E. A., et al. (2013). Parent praise to 1- to 3-year-olds predicts children's motivational frameworks 5 years later. Child Development, 84(5), 1526–1541.

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